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And he also was buried

in the church of blessed Peter in | in the basilica of blessed Peter,
the Vatican,² | the apostle,

November 19.

And the bishopric was empty 4 days.

LIII. SYMMACHUS (498-514)

Symmachus, by nationality a Sardinian,³ son of Fortunatus, occupied the see 15 years, 7 months and 27 days.

He was bishop in the time of Theodoric,

the heretic,⁴ | the king,

and Anastasius Augustus,

the Eutychian, |

from November 22 to July 19.

that Acacius' name be allowed to drop and assured the emperor that the baptisms and ordinations performed by Acacius and his followers would be accepted as valid at Rome. Jaffé, *Regesta*, vol. I, p. 95, 744. These overtures produced an effect at least upon the bishop of Thessalonica, who thereupon had the letter of Gelasius denouncing Acacius read publicly in the churches of his diocese and who dispatched a deacon, Photinus, to renew in his behalf communion with the Roman see. Jaffé, *ibid.*, 746. Unfortunately a zealot party at Rome disapproved of the pope's conciliatory attitude and ascribed to him, as in the text, a design to abandon the principles and to rescind the acts of Felix III and Gelasius. Thus arose a schism within the Roman church itself which was to break out violently after Anastasius' death. The fact that Anastasius died soon after his resumption of relations with the church at Thessalonica was looked upon by his opponents as a clear proof of divine displeasure. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, pp. xliii and 258, n. 3.

¹ List of ordinations.

² Duchesne gives his epitaph. *Op. cit.*, p. 259, n. 5.

³ Symmachus said of himself that he came out of paganism and learned the catholic faith at Rome. Duchesne, *Lib. Pont.*, vol. I, p. 263, n. 1.

⁴ Mommsen argues that if the *Lib. Pont.* had been composed early in the sixth century under Ostrogothic rule, as Duchesne maintains that it was, the derogatory epithet of "heretic" could not have been applied to Theodoric. Mommsen, *Lib. Pont.*, p. xvii. On Theodoric's relations with the Roman Church see Gregorovius, *History of Rome*, tr. Hamilton, vol. I, pp. 311-333.

He loved the clergy and the poor; he was a good man and sagacious, kindly and courteous, and at the time of his ordination Laurentius also was ordained because of a dissension in the bishopric,¹

He was ordained on the same day with Laurentius because there was a dissension,

Symmachus in the basilica of Constantine and Laurentius in the basilica of the blessed Mary.

Wherefore

one party of the clergy and also of the senators was divided from the rest

the clergy was separated into parties and the senate also was divided

and some supported Symmachus and others Laurentius. And after the dissension had arisen

they all alike

the parties

decided that both factions should betake themselves to Ravenna for the judgment of Theodoric.² And

when they had come

when they had both arrived at Ravenna

they received this righteous judgment, that he who had been first ordained or who

was supported by

was known to have

the largest party should occupy the apostolic see. Thus through justice and perception of the truth Symmachus was selected and made bishop. At that time Pope Symmachus assembled a synod and appointed Laurentius bishop of the town of Nuceria out of compassion.³

¹ There is no mention here of the theological and political reasons underlying the split in the Roman church but the situation may be better appreciated if the reader recalls the beginning of discord under Anastasius II. *Supra*, p. 114 and n. 3. Laurentius seems to have been the candidate of the party that desired more compromise with the Eastern church.

² Other versions of the story say that the contending parties were forced to accept the arbitration of Theodoric. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 263, n. 4.

³ The acts of the synod of Italian bishops, held under the presidency of Symmachus in 499, have been preserved. They consist chiefly of measures to prevent confusion in

But after 4 years¹ some of the clergy and some of the senate,
in particular Festus and Probinus, full of zeal
and craft, |
brought charges against Symmachus and suborned false witnesses
whom they sent to King Theodoric,
the heretic, |
at Ravenna to accuse the blessed Symmachus; and they recalled
Laurentius stealthily
to Rome, |
after the accusation had been drawn up at Rome; and they created
a schism and
a party withdrew itself from | the clergy was divided again and
communion with Symmachus.² | some communicated with Sym-
machus and some with Lauren-
tius.

Then the senators Festus and Probinus sent a report to the king
and asked King Theodoric to | and began to negotiate with the
send Peter of Altinum³ as an | king to send an inspector to the
inspector to the apostolic see. | apostolic see. Then the king
sent Peter, bishop of the town
of Altinum, although the canons
forbade it.

future papal elections. During the synod Laurentius was appointed bishop of Nocera.
Jaffé, *Regesta*, vol. I, p. 96. Hefele, *op. cit.*, vol. II, p. 958.

¹ In fact early in 501.

² The first accusation brought by the malcontents against Symmachus concerned the date of Easter. Symmachus had celebrated that festival in 501 on March 25, following the old Roman calendar. Jaffé, *Regesta*, p. 97, 754. His adversaries complained that he should have adopted the Greek reckoning, which brought the date to April 22. Symmachus went to Rimini to lay his case before Theodoric and while there learned of other and graver charges which were being preferred against him: *viz.*, violation of chastity and misuse of church property. Thereupon, without waiting to face Theodoric, he fled back to Rome by night and entrenched himself in the buildings of the Vatican. The hostile party took advantage of his flight to prevail upon Theodoric to send a "visitor" or inspector to Rome in order to celebrate Easter at the proper season, as the emperor Honorius had done at the time of the dissension between Boniface I and Eulalius. *Supra*, p. 89, n. 4; p. 90. The act, however, was tantamount to a declaration that the see of Rome was vacant or contested. Symmachus was bound to resent it as a negation of all his rights. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 264, n. 8. Jaffé, *ibid.*, p. 97.

³ The modern Altino near Venice.

Then the blessed Symmachus assembled 115 bishops and in the synod was acquitted of the false accusation and Peter of Altinum, the intruder upon the apostolic see, and Laurentius of Nuceria were condemned, because during the lifetime of the bishop Symmachus they had invaded his see.¹ Then the blessed Symmachus was reinstated with glory in the apostolic see by all the bishops, priests and deacons and all the clergy and the people, to sit as bishop in the church of the blessed Peter.

Then Festus, the patrician, began to slaughter in the city the clergy who were communicating with the blessed Symmachus³ and he expelled consecrated women from their dwell-

At that time Festus, the ex-consul and leader of the senate,² and Probinus, the exconsul, began to fight in the city of Rome with other senators, in particular with Faustus, the exconsul,

¹ The Roman synod of 501 was convened to pass on the whole situation by order of Theodoric and with the consent of Symmachus. It held three sessions, the first during the spring or early summer at the church of Santa Maria in Trastevere. At this session Symmachus agreed to appear, waiving the claim of his see not to be judged by inferiors and overlooking the fact that Theodoric had seized the lands and buildings of the church, leaving him only St. Peter's. The second session met in September at the basilica of Santa Croce in Gerusalemme on the farther side of the city. Symmachus set out to cross from the Vatican but was attacked by a band of enemies on the way and many of the priests accompanying him were killed. Thereafter Symmachus remained shut up in the Vatican and refused to attend another session of the synod. Nevertheless in October the assembled bishops declared that they could find no reason why he should not continue in full enjoyment of his office and left the accusations against him to the judgment of God. They solemnly condemned both Laurentius and Peter of Altino, Theodoric's "visitor." In November, 502, Symmachus on his own initiative called another synod of bishops, which proceeded to annul an irregular decree forbidding the pope to alienate church property, that seems to have been employed by Symmachus' opponents as a basis for their charges against him. *Supra*, p. 110, n. 3. The synod indeed passed other ordinances prohibiting the pope to dispose of rural property but allowing him to sell city houses which cost too much to maintain. In 505 Symmachus petitioned Theodoric to compel the patrician Festus, the instigator of the violence which continued to harass the city, to abstain from further opposition and to order Laurentius to leave Rome. Dioscorus, a young deacon from Alexandria, was able to persuade Theodoric to take this step and Symmachus resumed possession of all the churches and ecclesiastical estates. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 264, n. 10. Jaffé, *Regesta*, pp. 97-98. Hefele, *loc. cit.* Dioscorus' powers of eloquence served the Roman church even more conspicuously later. *Infra*, pp. 127-130.

² Festus was consul in 472, Probinus in 489 and Faustus in 490. They are all three mentioned as persons of high reputation in a contemporary work by Ennodius. *Opusc.* VI. Quoted by Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 265, n. 12.

³ This passage is not probably descriptive of any one occasion but of the general

ings, and stripped women of their clothing and beat them with clubs and he killed many priests there,

and, in their hatred, to commit slaughter and murder upon the clergy who rightfully communicated with the blessed Symmachus and they killed with the sword publicly those who were found within the city. Also they expelled consecrated women and virgins from their convents and their dwellings and they stripped women of their clothing and wounded them with blows and stripes; and daily they waged war against the church in the midst of the city. Likewise they slew many priests,

among them Dignissimus and Gordianus,¹ priests of Saint ² Peter, the apostle, "ad Vincula," and of Saints John and Paul, whom they did to death with cudgels and sword; also many other Christians, so that it was unsafe for one of the clergy to walk abroad in the city by day or by night. Only Faustus, the exconsul, fought for the church.

After all this the blessed Symmachus found Manicheans in the city of Rome and burned with fire all their images and books before

state of lawlessness and tumult which lasted during the years before Symmachus was finally and decisively reinstated. The people as a whole seem to have supported Symmachus but a party of the clergy and a majority of the Senate were bitter against him.

¹ The name of Dignissimus does not appear on the list of parish priests who took part in the synod of 499, perhaps because the basilica which he served was not counted among the parish churches. Gordianus is registered as priest of Santi Giovanni e Paolo. He was the father of Pope Agapitus. *Infra*, p. 143 and n. 6. Both undoubtedly perished early in the disturbances, for neither was among the priests loyal to Symmachus who attended the synod of November, 502. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 265, n. 13.

² From the sixth century onward the word "sanctus" was an official title, applied only to the distinguished dead who were publicly venerated in the churches, no longer a general epithet for all bishops or even, as in primitive times, for all believers, living or dead. Hereafter, therefore, in our text the word will usually be translated "saint," instead of the vaguer "holy."

³ The church of San Pietro in Vincoli was built during the fifth century by the empress Eudoxia to receive the relic of the chains of Peter.

the doors of the basilica of Constantine and condemned them to exile.¹

He was bishop from the consulship of Paulinus (A.D. 498) to the consulship of Senator (A.D. 514).²

He built the basilica of Saint Andrew, the apostle, near the basilica of the blessed Peter.³

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Also he adorned with marbles the basilica of blessed Peter.

The fountain of blessed Peter with the square portico around it he beautified with marble work and with lambs and crosses and palms of mosaic. Likewise he enclosed the whole atrium; and he widened the steps before the doors of the basilica of Saint Peter, the apostle, and he made other steps of wood on the right and on the left. Also he built palaces in the same place on the right and on the left. Also, below the steps into the atrium, outside in the

¹ This event must have taken place after the emperor Anastasius accused Symmachus himself of being a Manichean, probably during the latter half of his pontificate. Symmachus wrote an *Apologeticus* in his own defence. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 265, n. 14. Jaffé, *Regesta*, p. 99, 761.

² This is the first consular synchronism since the close of the *Liberian Catalogue*. Synchronisms are given for the three following popes as well. Duchesne regards their appearance here as another proof that the *Lib. Pont.* was first compiled between 514 and 530. *Op. cit.*, p. xlv.

³ Symmachus was peculiarly concerned to enlarge and beautify the basilica of St. Peter, perhaps out of gratitude for the shelter it afforded him during his years of struggle, 501-506. The basilica of St. Andrew was a rotunda which stood beside the church of St. Peter until it was demolished by Pius VI to make room for the present sacristy. It seems to have been built originally during the fifth century, together with a second circular structure which stood behind it and was connected with it and with St. Peter's by a gallery. The two were apparently intended as mausoleums for the family of Theodosius and the rear building actually contained some imperial tombs. It was called in the Middle Ages the chapel of Santa Petronilla. The rotunda which Symmachus now converted into a church and dedicated to St. Andrew had presumably never been used as a mausoleum and was empty until he furnished it. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 265, n. 16.

⁴ List of gifts to the shrine of St. Andrew and of four oratories constructed within the rotunda; also of three oratories built about the baptistery of St. Peter, which stood at the end of the north transept of the basilica. These last three oratories were dedicated to the Holy Cross, St. John the Baptist and St. John the Evangelist respectively, as were the oratories attached to the baptistery of the Lateran. *Supra*, p. 103. Symmachus may have equipped the Vatican baptistery to serve instead of the Lateran during his exclusion from the latter.